

121 GROUP · GUIDE

User Hierarchy

How authority and access work in the agency PM tool.

AUTHOR

Nikko Trinidad

AUDIENCE

Leadership and team members

The big idea

Every person in the agency carries two parallel pieces of identity in the PM tool. The first is their **access tier**: Owner, Admin, Manager, Member, or Viewer. The second is their **job title**: Operations Manager, Account Manager, Web Developer, and so on.

The two move independently. A team member's access tier changes when their authority changes. Their job title changes when their identity changes. Both matter, and keeping them separate is deliberate.

This document covers three things:

- The five access tiers and what each one can do.
- How every job title at 121 Group maps to a tier.
- How the Manager and Member tiers are scoped to the clients they are assigned to, so each team member sees only the work in front of them.

WHY THIS DOCUMENT EXISTS

Most permission systems either over-grant access (everyone can see everything, then trust solves the rest) or under-grant access (nobody can do anything without a request). Neither works at scale. This model gives the agency a clear answer to two questions a team member or a leader might ask on any given day: **what can I do**, and **who can change that**.

Two dimensions, not one

Most tools collapse authority and identity into a single field. That works in small teams. It breaks the moment titles change for reasons that have nothing to do with what someone is allowed to do. Or the moment leadership wants to recognise senior expertise without granting administrative power.

The model separates the two cleanly:

Access tier

Controls what someone can do inside the tool. There are exactly five tiers, ordered by authority: Owner, Admin, Manager, Member, Viewer. Each tier owns a specific set of actions and surfaces. Changing a tier changes power.

Job title

Describes who someone is and what they do. It is the label on their profile, the chip on assignee pickers, the line in the team roster. Many job titles can sit at the same access tier. An Account Manager and a Project Manager are both Manager tier; a Web Developer and a Graphic Designer are both Member tier.

THE RULE OF THUMB

Title change $\neq$ access change. Promoting a designer to *Senior Designer* changes their title but keeps them at Member tier. Promoting them to *Design Lead* probably changes both: Manager tier plus the new title. The two moves are independent, and the Operations Manager makes each one explicitly.

Why this matters

If we tied access to job title, every title change in HR would ripple through permissions in unintended ways. A name change from *Strategist* to *Senior Strategist* should not suddenly grant approval rights over someone else's time off. Keeping them separate means the tool stays honest about authority even as titles evolve.

Authority, one row at a time

Tier	Headcount	What they own
Owner	Exactly 1	Ownership of the workspace itself.
Admin	1 or more	Day-to-day operations.
Manager	Several	Client relationships and project delivery.
Member	Most of the team	Production work on assigned cards.
Viewer	External only	Read-only access on whatever the team grants them.

Owner

Exactly one person, full stop. The Managing Director carries this tier. Owner's specific powers are narrow: transferring ownership to someone else, and deleting the workspace entirely. Everything else they do day-to-day flows through their inherited Admin powers.

Owner cannot be removed by anyone else, and there cannot be two Owners at the same time. Ownership transfer is a deliberate single-action move that hands the workspace to a new person and demotes the previous Owner.

Admin

Runs the workspace day to day. The Operations Manager holds this tier. Admin's powers cover almost everything except ownership and deletion of the workspace:

- Approves time off requests across the team.
- Edits the Ops board.
- Adds, removes, and changes access tiers for Manager, Member, and Viewer roles.
- Manages the workspace identity (name, logo, colour).
- Manages job titles, holidays, leave guidelines, and Trash.

Admin **cannot** assign or revoke another Admin role. That stays with Owner. This keeps the agency's elevated-access population stable.

Manager

Owns client relationships and runs project delivery. The Account Manager, Account Executive, Head of Strategy, Head of Design and Development, SEM Manager, SEO Manager, and Paid Social Manager sit here.

Managers can:

- Assign tasks to Members on their clients' boards.
- Create new clients, services, and cards.
- Edit and create templates.
- View the Ops board (read-only).
- Submit and manage their own time off.

Managers cannot:

- Approve other people's time off. (That sits with Admin.)
- Add or remove members at any tier.
- Edit the Ops board.
- Archive or delete clients.

Member

Production team. Most of the agency sits here. Members do the actual work on the cards they are assigned to. The WordPress Developer, SEO Specialist, Graphic Designer, Web Designer, SEO Link Building Manager, GTM & GMC Specialist, SEO Assistant, Email Marketing Specialist, Meta Ads Specialist, IT Specialist, Google Ads Specialist, Chief Prompt Engineer, and ML Ops & AI Application Developer all sit at this tier.

Members edit their own cards, move them between columns, comment on any card they can see, and submit their own time off. They cannot create or edit other people's cards, cannot assign work to others, and cannot create or edit clients.

ABOUT THE JOB TITLES WITH "MANAGER" OR "CHIEF" AT MEMBER TIER

Some senior specialists carry titles that sound managerial but are not. **SEO Link Building Manager** and **Chief Prompt Engineer** are both Member tier. The word in the title recognises seniority and depth; the tier reflects that they do not actually manage other people. This is deliberate and consistent with how senior individual contributors are recognised across the agency.

Viewer

Viewer is reserved for **external entities outside the organisation**, like clients. It is a read-only tier with the narrowest set of permissions, intended for the client-portal flow where a client logs in to see progress on their own work.

Nobody internal to 121 Group should be issued a Viewer tier. If an intern or probationary employee needs read-only access while they ramp up, they sit at the Member tier with whatever scoping the Operations Manager grants. Viewer is the wrong tool for that.

The client-portal flow itself is not yet built. Until it lands, Viewer functions as a placeholder so the access ladder stays complete and the model is ready for the moment leadership decides to invite clients in.

How every title maps to a tier

Use this table to look up your job title and find your access tier. The list reflects 121 Group's current roster. New titles are added by the Operations Manager when the team grows.

Access tier	Job titles
Owner	• Managing Director
Admin	• Operations Manager
Manager	• SEM Manager • Head of Strategy • Head of Design and Development • SEO Manager • Paid Social Manager • Account Manager • Account Executive
Member	• WordPress Developer • SEO Specialist • Graphic Designer • Web Designer • SEO Link Building Manager • GTM & GMC Specialist • SEO Assistant • Email Marketing Specialist • Meta Ads Specialist • IT Specialist • Google Ads Specialist • Chief Prompt Engineer • ML Ops & AI Application Developer
Viewer	• Reserved for external entities only (e.g. clients).

Why Manager and Member only see their clients

Owner and Admin see every client in the workspace. They need the full picture to run the agency.

Manager and Member tiers see only the clients they are **assigned to**. This keeps each team member focused on the work in front of them, and keeps confidential client context from spreading further than it needs to.

A team member is "assigned to" a client when any of these are true:

- They are the client's Account Manager.
- They are on the client's team (added through the About tab on the client detail).
- They have at least one card assigned to them on one of the client's services. This covers ad-hoc work. A designer who picks up a one-off card for a client they are not formally on the team for still gets full context for that client.

What "full context" means

Once a team member is assigned to a client, they see the whole client (every service, every board, every card on those boards). Card-level editing is still gated separately: a Member can only edit cards they themselves are assigned to. The surrounding context, though, is visible.

This is intentional. If a team member is trusted enough to do work on a card, they are trusted enough to see what else is happening on the same client. The opposite (work in isolation, with no visibility into related work) produces conflicts more often than it prevents them.

What happens when assignment changes

Client visibility is recomputed live from the underlying data. The moment a team member is removed from a client's team, removed as Account Manager, and has no remaining card assignments on that client's services, the client drops out of their view on the next page load. There is no separate permission to revoke.

What every tier can do, action by action

Use this table as a lookup when a question comes up about whether a tier can perform a specific action. **Yes** means allowed. **No** means blocked. **Assigned only** means allowed for clients the team member is assigned to. **View only** means read access without edit rights. **Own only** means scoped to the team member's own work.

Workspace administration

Action	Owner	Admin	Manager	Member	Viewer
Edit workspace identity (name, logo, colour)	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
View members list	Yes	Yes	View only	View only	No
Invite teammate (generate invite link)	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
Assign Admin tier	Yes	No	No	No	No
Assign Manager / Member / Viewer tier	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
Remove member	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
Edit member capacity caps	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
Manage job titles catalogue	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
Manage holidays (sync, add, import/export)	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
View / restore / empty Trash	Yes	Yes	No	No	No

Time off

Action	Owner	Admin	Manager	Member	Viewer
Submit own time-off request	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
Approve or deny anyone's request	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
Edit coverage rules	Yes	Yes	No	No	No

View team-wide balances (Ops → Balances)	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
Edit Leave Guidelines	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
View Leave Guidelines (read-only)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No

Ops board

Action	Owner	Admin	Manager	Member	Viewer
See Ops in navigation	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No
View Ops board (cards + capacity heatmap)	Yes	Yes	View only	No	No
Edit Ops board (drag, assign, edit tasks)	Yes	Yes	No	No	No

Clients and services

Action	Owner	Admin	Manager	Member	Viewer
View clients list	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	Assigned only	No
Create new client	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No
Edit client header (industry, manager, website)	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	No	No
Archive or delete client	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
Add or edit contacts and quick links	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	No	No
Edit client notes	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	Assigned only	No
Create service	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	No	No
Edit service settings	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	No	No
Archive or delete service	Yes	Yes	No	No	No

Kanban boards (cards)

Action	Owner	Admin	Manager	Member	Viewer
View boards	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	Assigned only	No
Create cards	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	No	No
Assign cards to other members	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	No	No
Edit cards assigned to self	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	Assigned only	No
Edit cards assigned to others	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	No	No
Comment on cards	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
Move cards between columns	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	Own only	No
Archive cards	Yes	Yes	Assigned only	No	No

Templates

Action	Owner	Admin	Manager	Member	Viewer
See Templates in navigation	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No
View templates list	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No
Create, edit, archive templates	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No
Reset built-in template to default	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No

Other surfaces

Action	Owner	Admin	Manager	Member	Viewer
View Home dashboard	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
View Analytics	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No

View Weekly WIP meeting flow	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Create Weekly WIP captures / action items	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No

Workspace ownership

Action	Owner	Admin	Manager	Member	Viewer
Transfer workspace ownership	Yes	No	No	No	No
Delete workspace	Yes	No	No	No	No

Quick definitions for the terms in this doc

Access tier

One of the five levels of authority: Owner, Admin, Manager, Member, Viewer. Changes when leadership changes someone's power, not when their title changes.

Job title

The label on a team member's profile, used in assignee pickers and the team roster. Many job titles can sit at the same access tier. Title changes are surface-level and do not change permissions.

Client scoping

The rule that Manager and Member tiers see only the clients they are assigned to. Owner and Admin see every client.

Assigned (to a client)

A team member is assigned to a client when they are the client's Account Manager, on the client's team, or have at least one card assigned to them on one of the client's services.

Ownership transfer

The mechanism for handing the Owner tier to a different person. Not yet built; planned. Until it lands, the Owner is whoever signed in to create the workspace.

Probationary status

A separate flag on each team member that controls paid-leave entitlement. Probationary members can submit leave requests, but every approved day is flagged unpaid until they are marked Regular. This is independent of access tier. A probationary designer is still Member tier.

Operations Manager

A job title commonly held by the person who carries the Admin tier. The title sits on their profile; the tier governs what they can do.

QUESTIONS OR DISAGREEMENTS

If a rule in this document feels wrong for how the agency actually operates, raise it with the Author. The model is allowed to evolve. The intent is honesty, not stability for its own sake.